SKANDA VAIDYANATH

Founding AI Researcher, Yutori

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EDUCATION

M.S. Computer Science A.I. Track
Stanford University

Sep 2021 – Jun 2023

- **CGPA: 4.06/4**

B.E. (Hons.) Computer Science with a Minor in Data Science
BITS Pilani, Hyderabad Campus

Jun 2016 – May 2020

- **Class valedictorian.**
- **CGPA: 9.93/10, Major CGPA (only CS courses): 10.00/10**

RECENT EXPERIENCE

Founding AI Researcher
Yutori

Feb 2025 – Present | San Francisco, California

- Post-trained the Navigator n1, n1.5, and n2 model series using reinforcement learning and self-distillation (GRPO variants and SDPO).
- Navigator n2 is a 27B computer-use model achieving **SOTA** results on four of five evaluated benchmarks.
- Built the agentic harness and backend for Scouts and Delegate.

Staff Research Scientist
Riot Games AI Accelerator

Jul 2023 – Feb 2025 | Redwood City, California

- Trained self-play policies for two-player zero-sum partially observable stochastic games, achieving professional-level performance.
- Developed game-theoretic extensions to asynchronous PPO based on R-NaD and magnetic mirror descent (MMD).
- Scaled self-play using large-scale distributed reinforcement learning.

Research Engineer Intern
Google DeepMind

Jun 2022 – Sep 2022 | Mountain View, California

- Co-developed PushWorld, a benchmark of 200+ puzzles for manipulation planning with movable obstacles and tools [paper].
- Evaluated classical planners and model-free RL agents; introduced a planning heuristic 40× faster than the strongest baseline.

Research Intern
Microsoft Research

Dec 2020 – Jul 2021 | Bangalore, India

- Built Jigsaw, a multi-modal system that synthesizes Pandas code from natural language and I/O examples using GPT-3 and Codex [paper].
- Developed program-analysis and synthesis post-processing to repair reference, argument, and semantic errors and learn from user feedback.

AWARDS, HONORS

- BITS Hyderabad Merit Scholarship for finishing in the top 1% of my graduating class every semester
- IUSSTF-Viterbi Scholar 2019. I was **one of fifteen students** chosen from India for the programme.
- Max Planck Institute for Informatics 2019 Research Scholar Fellowship

SELECT PUBLICATIONS

- Akash Velu*, **Skanda Vaidyanath***, Dilip Arumugam. Hindsight-DICE: Stable Credit Assignment for Deep Reinforcement Learning. *arXiv preprint, 2023.* [pdf]
- Divyansh Garg*, **Skanda Vaidyanath***, Kuno Kim, Jiaming Song, Stefano Ermon. LISA: Learning Interpretable Skill Abstractions from Language. *NeurIPS 2022* [pdf] [website]
- Naman Jain, **Skanda Vaidyanath**, Arun Iyer, Nagarajan Natarajan, Suresh Parthasarathy, Sriram Rajamani, Rahul Sharma. Jigsaw: Large Language Models meet Program Synthesis. *ICSE 2022* [pdf][blog]

ACTIVITIES

- Course Assistant, Deep Learning: CS230 Autumn 2022, Spring 2023
- Course Assistant, Artificial Intelligence: CS221 Spring 2022
- Course Assistant , Reinforcement Learning: CS234 Winter 2022, Winter 2023
- Research With Impact, SGSI 2021, Stanford University [link]
- Leadership Labs, SGSI 2020, Stanford University [link]

ML FRAMEWORKS

Miles | verl | LLaMA Factory | Transformers | vLLM | SGLang

SELECT COURSEWORK

Probabilistic Graphical Models | Convex Optimization | Reinforcement Learning | Meta-Learning | Graph Neural Networks | Randomized Algorithms